



Batman, a vampire?

Justice League: Gods and monsters chronicles has been launched, with an all-new Vampire-Batman. Read more: <http://dgit.in/btmnvmp>



Story of a wave

QBism, a 'story' by Christopher Fuchs, solves quantum theory's deepest secrets. Read more: <http://dgit.in/qntmrly>

While most of you would already know about the Xiaomi Mi Band, the other names may not be as well known. That doesn't stop them from being real competitors in an otherwise immature market though. Together, these devices form the first generation of smartbands, and they've set the stage for future generations. They have their negatives and positives, and have defined what to do and what not to do with wearables.

XIAOMI MI BAND

Everyone's favourite inexpensive wearable device, the Xiaomi Mi Band is, in our opinion exactly what the market needs for wearable tech to really come into the mainstream. Its USP is that it costs only ₹999, making it the cheapest smartband out there. The Mi Band is the device you buy when you want to just try out a wearable gadget and



Xiaomi Mi Band

aren't yet sure if you want to shell out the big bucks on such a device. It can give you a very good idea of what more advanced wearables can do.

While the Xiaomi Mi Band can track your steps, that's about all it can do. There are some issues here and there as well, and the Mi Band app seems like a work in progress. The app crashed every time we tried to share progress on social media and some of the

features, like notifications, are just not available in the official app. We tried the tweaked apk on the MiUI forums, but that didn't work either.

The Mi Band is really light and unintrusive though, which means you'll more or less forget that you're wearing it through the day. It weighs only about 13 grams and is made out of good quality polycarbonate. So, like we said before, you buy this if you're just looking to try a

smartband, but not if you really plan on using it.

FITGEN TREK

The Fitgen Trek seemed like a very promising smartband when we first heard about it. The band has its own database of Indian foods, which earns a lot of points from us. This means you can input the food you eat into the app and it then measures your calorie intake. It makes up for one of the biggest weaknesses of the Mi Band, the fact that you couldn't do anything with the data that you got from that band. The Fitgen Trek can count the number of calories you've burned based on your steps, while putting it side by side with the number of calories you've consumed through your food data.

Unfortunately, the Trek's database isn't exactly effective. It asks for the user to input the exact amount of each food they've had, which is difficult

HOW WE TESTED

It's important to establish a few ground rules first. With the prices that companies are asking, should a fitness band be just that, or are additional features important? Of course it should be the latter, which means that a display, features like smart alarms, receiving calls or reading texts etc. are important for smartbands. Of course, you must also be able to use it as a watch, meaning it must show the time.

Next, it is also important for a smartband to have good battery life. You wouldn't want to charge such a device every day, especially considering that they're meant to be on your person all the time. The band can't track your data when it's charging, and if you want it to track sleep as well, then charging overnight also goes out the windows. Of course, you have to charge it after some time, but it has to be a reasonable amount of time. The Xiaomi Mi Band for example, lasts for over a month, which is ideal for a smartband. That said, the battery life deteriorates as you add features.

To actually compare the devices, we used them both separately and together. While using them together draws direct comparison between them, separately one can judge their individual merits and demerits. The performance of each smartband includes their performance individually and in comparison. We took into consideration the various features each offered, while testing the accuracy of their sensors by performing a variety of movements. The Timex IRONMAN Move X20 for example, tends to measure steps when in a slow moving vehicle.

Next comes the partner app, which none of these wearables can function without. The Xiaomi Mi Band works using the Mi Fit app, while the Huawei Talkband B2 works using the Huawei Wear app. The compatibility of these apps are usually on both Android and iOS, but some have also taken the jump to work on Windows as well. Apart from the compatibility, like any other app, these apps also have to be simple, intuitive and easy to use, gentler the learning curve, the better. In addition, if the

app is always running on the background and eating up resources, then that's a negative, since having a smartband doesn't necessarily mean you should also need a high end mobile phone. We judged the apps just like we do any other, while adding points for extra features which the app was responsible for adding, like smart alarms etc.

Finally, wearable tech has as much to do with technology as it does with fashion. Any smartband needs to look good and should be able to seamlessly be a part of your overall getup, just like watches are. Hence, the design of a smartband is important.

Not only the looks, the kind of material used to make the band is very important, too, as is the sturdiness of the device. Things like water resistance or water proofing can be important for something that will be on your person at all times. Like in smartphones, metal is also favourable here, but companies have to also ensure that the device is light enough to not be intrusive.